



ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

quo, smash cartels and create new markets. Naresh Goyal was a humble travel agent who cobbled together some funds and built a world class airline. Capital will eventually find entrepreneurs who have revolutionary ideas. In the past decade and a half, Kingfisher Airlines, which took over Air Deccan, Jet Airways, and Go First have gone belly up. SpiceJet, a remarkable feat of survival, has shrunk from 100 jets to under 30. All in all, more than 300 airplanes have exited the country. IndiGo has grown to become a large behemoth, but the market itself has not expanded proportionately. The Tatas have repossessed a doddering, bleeding Air India. And we now have a duopoly, which does not augur well.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's

'Startup India' campaign is laudable, but it must spread to other areas. Aviation is integral to equitable economic growth and to be globally competitive. With mega airports controlling air and ground space it's well-nigh impossible to connect regional towns and large metros, despite the commendable UDAN initiative. And where slots are available with difficulty, costs are prohibitive. We need multiple airports that compete just as we need many airlines with different stakeholders.

Our air cargo growth is languishing. Hong Kong airport alone handles more cargo than all our 100 airports put together. Air cargo integrated with road, rail and ports is the artery of a growing economy.

Besides, the Maintenance, Repair

and Overhaul (MRO) space is in an utterly dismal state. The labyrinthine taxes, customs and other duties and tortuous rules to bring in parts and repair and overhaul, and re-export or use on our aircraft is a deterrent and all airlines send their aircraft for major MRO to Dubai, Singapore or elsewhere. Similarly, the charter business has remained stagnant. It's the training ground for pilots and engineers. The irony is that we have around 4,000 pilots

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and thousands of technicians who are unemployed, but we bring in foreign pilots and engineers, pushing up costs. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation cadre needs to be modernised, motivated and incentivised. It must be helmed by aviation professionals.

Despite these setbacks, there are silver linings. Whatever else India may not possess, it has an inexhaustible market and largely untapped potential. That gives hope. Policymakers need to ask themselves only one question: What should the government do to make common Indians fly? That will show the road map to the future. **BT**

Views are personal